MODULE 19 · DOMAIN 5 - CONFIGURATION AND KNOWLEDGE MANAGEMENT

Writing System-Level Instructions That Work

Purpose and boundaries first, specific and conditional rules, finding contradictions, and the three layers of instruction.

DOMAIN 5 of 7 EXAM WEIGHT 12% MODULE 19 of 33

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Write instructions for **a brilliant new colleague** who has never seen your company.

Writing instructions: the sequence

01

Purpose and boundaries

What the Project is for; what it must never do.

02

Role and audience

Who Claude is here, and who reads the output.

03

Standards

Voice, structure, length.

04

Conditional rules

If this, then that; otherwise this.

05

Test and refine

Real cases; one change at a time.

ON THE EXAM

Purpose and boundaries before any rule about tone.

The building blocks, vague and specific

BLOCK	VAGUE	SPECIFIC: HALDEN APOLOGY PROJECT
Role	A helpful assistant	Drafts apology emails for account managers to review
Voice	Professional	Formal British English; no contractions
Structure	Clear	Apology, what happened, what we are doing, next visit, contact
Length	Keep it short	120 to 180 words
Conditional	Offer a credit	A goodwill credit only where the policy allows
Boundary	(none)	Never promise dates or refunds not in the ticket

ON THE EXAM

Every vague word leaves Claude to guess. Every specific one removes a guess.

What Anthropic's guidance adds

- **Explain why.** "Read aloud by a text-to-speech engine, so never use ellipses" beats "NEVER use ellipses".
- **Say what to do,** not only what to avoid: "smoothly flowing prose paragraphs", not "no markdown".
- **A role in one sentence** focuses behaviour and tone.
- **Match your instruction style to the output you want,** and number steps when order matters.

> THE TIEBREAKER
>
> "Claude is smart enough to generalize from the explanation." A reason travels further than a rule.

Conditional rules

- **Write the condition and the alternative:** "If X, do Y; otherwise, do Z."
- **Credits:** offer one only when the ticket shows a missed visit within the policy; otherwise, flag for the account manager.
- **Safety:** if a complaint mentions an injury or hazard, do not draft; tell the account manager to escalate.
- **Unclear case:** if the ticket lacks a visit date, ask for it rather than inventing one.

> ON THE EXAM
>
> A blanket rule breaks on its exceptions. A conditional rule names them.

Examples inside instructions

- **Three to five relevant, varied examples** teach a pattern faster than paragraphs of description.
- **Mark them as examples,** so Claude learns the pattern rather than copying the wording.
- **Vary them:** a missed clean, a late repair, a repeat complaint. One example breeds clones.
- **Examples must obey the rules.** One sample email with a contraction teaches contractions.

> THE TIEBREAKER
>
> Claude copies what you show more faithfully than what you tell. Make the examples perfect.

Finding contradictions

- **Inside the instructions:** "be brief" and "always explain the full background".
- **Instructions against knowledge:** "be casual" while the brand guide forbids contractions.
- **Between layers:** an account-wide instruction pulling against the Project's.
- **How to find them:** list every rule, test edge cases, and ask Claude which instructions conflict or are ambiguous.

THE TIEBREAKER

Inconsistent outputs often mean two rules pulling in opposite directions. Decide which wins, and when.

Three layers of instruction

LAYER	SCOPE	USE IT FOR
Styles	Chosen per chat: Normal, Concise, Formal, Explanatory, or custom	How a reply reads, right now
Instructions for Claude	Your account: all your conversations	Personal preferences, such as British spelling
Project instructions	Only chats in that Project, for everyone in it	Team rules, standards and boundaries

ON THE EXAM

Team rules belong in Project instructions, not in one person's account settings.

Quirk 2: the apology instructions, rebuilt

BEFORE

Three vague phrases

- "Be warm and casual"
- "Keep it short"
- "Offer a goodwill credit"
- Result: too brief, contractions, credits the policy forbids

AFTER

Specific and conditional

- Formal British English; no contractions; warm through specifics
- 120 to 180 words, in five fixed parts
- Credit only where the policy allows; otherwise flag
- Never promise dates or refunds not in the ticket

THE SIGNAL

Each failure maps to one vague phrase. Fix each phrase, then re-test.

Testing and maintaining instructions

- **Test on five recent real cases,** including awkward ones: an angry client, a repeat miss, a safety mention.
- **Check each rule against each output.** Which rules held, and which slipped?
- **Change one rule at a time,** and re-run the same cases.
- **Date and version the instructions;** review them when a policy, brand or process changes.

> THE TIEBREAKER
>
> Instructions are a living document. When the policy changes, the instructions change the same week.

Instruction traps

THE TRAP	WHY IT FAILS
Tone words with no definition	"Professional" means something different to everyone
Blanket rules with exceptions	Breach the policy on the exception
Adding a rule to fix a contradiction	Now three rules disagree
Team rules in personal account settings	Only one person's chats follow them
Rules in capitals with no reason	Followed literally, never generalised
Never revisiting the instructions	Policy moves on; the Project does not

ON THE EXAM

Every trap leaves Claude guessing, or leaves the rule in the wrong layer.

> Quirk 2: Halden's apology Project instructions say "Be warm and casual, keep it short, offer a goodwill credit."
>
> Drafts are too brief, use contractions the brand forbids, and offer credits the policy does not allow.

What is the best fix?

A. Rewrite the instructions with specific rules: formal British English without contractions, a stated word range, and a credit only where the policy allows

B. Add "be more professional" to the existing instructions

C. Switch the Project to a more capable model

D. Ask account managers to correct each draft by hand

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

What is the best fix?

A Rewrite the instructions with specific rules: formal British English without contractions, a stated word range, and a credit only where the policy allows

Each vague phrase replaced by a specific, conditional rule.

B Add "be more professional" to the existing instructions

Another vague phrase, now contradicting "casual".

C Switch the Project to a more capable model

The model is following the instructions it was given.

D Ask account managers to correct each draft by hand

Permanent manual work for a fixable cause.

THE SIGNAL

Each failure traces to a vague phrase: make every phrase specific and conditional.

> Halden's marketing Project instruction for the supervisor newsletter says "Write in an engaging tone."
>
> Each month's draft reads differently, and supervisors say it is hard to read on their phones.

Which replacement instruction is best?

A Be very engaging

B Write like a professional copywriter

C Use your best judgement on tone

D Short sentences, active voice, one practical tip per item and British spelling, because supervisors read it on their phones

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

Which replacement instruction is best?

A Be very engaging

Still vague, only louder.

B Write like a professional copywriter

A role with no standard attached.

C Use your best judgement on tone

Hands the decision straight back to Claude.

D Short sentences, active voice, one practical tip per item and British spelling, because supervisors read it on their phones

Specific standards, plus the reason behind them.

THE SIGNAL

Inconsistent and hard to read on phones: specific standards, with the reason.

> Halden's HR team is writing instructions for its policy Project, which site supervisors use to ask questions about staff policies.

Which two belong in the Project instructions? Choose two.

A. A role: answer site supervisors' policy questions from the handbook, in plain English

B. A conditional rule: if a question involves a disciplinary or health matter, refer the supervisor to HR instead of answering

C. The full text of the staff handbook

D. The name of the supervisor asking today's question

E. A note that last Friday's question about holiday pay was answered wrongly

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

Which two belong in the Project instructions? Choose two.

A. A role: answer site supervisors' policy questions from the handbook, in plain English

A stable role and audience: instructions.

B. A conditional rule: if a question involves a disciplinary or health matter, refer the supervisor to HR instead of answering

A stable boundary, written conditionally: instructions.

C. The full text of the staff handbook

Reference material: knowledge.

D. The name of the supervisor asking today's question

Today's specific: the prompt.

E. A note that last Friday's question about holiday pay was answered wrongly

A one-off incident; fix the cause, not a note.

THE SIGNAL

Stable role and boundaries in instructions; reference in knowledge; specifics in the prompt.

Halden's customer success lead is rebuilding the apology Project's instructions after complaints about the drafts.

(1) Test the new instructions on recent real complaints.

(2) Read the current instructions and list each rule they actually state.

(3) Rewrite them as specific, conditional rules.

(4) Compare recent drafts with the brand guide and credit policy to find where they break.

(5) Share the updated instructions and set a review date.

What is the correct order?

A 2, 4, 3, 1, 5

B 4, 2, 3, 1, 5

C 2, 3, 4, 1, 5

D 2, 4, 1, 3, 5

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

What is the correct order?

A 2, 4, 3, 1, 5

Read, find the breaks, rewrite, test, share.

B 4, 2, 3, 1, 5

Judges the drafts before knowing what the rules say.

C 2, 3, 4, 1, 5

Rewrites before finding what is broken.

D 2, 4, 1, 3, 5

Tests instructions that have not been rewritten yet.

THE SIGNAL

Diagnose before you rewrite; test before you share.

> Halden's client-query Project instructions say "Keep every reply under 100 words" and, further down, "Always explain the full background of the issue."
>
> Some replies are brief and thin; others are long and ignore the limit.

What is the best fix?

A Switch to a more capable model that can satisfy both rules

B Add a third rule asking Claude to balance brevity and detail

C Resolve the conflict: keep replies brief, and give the full background only when the client asks for it

D Delete all the Project instructions and start again

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

What is the best fix?

A Switch to a more capable model that can satisfy both rules

No model can satisfy two rules that contradict.

B Add a third rule asking Claude to balance brevity and detail

A third rule, and the conflict is still unresolved.

C Resolve the conflict: keep replies brief, and give the full background only when the client asks for it

Decides which rule wins, and when.

D Delete all the Project instructions and start again

Throws away everything that worked.

THE SIGNAL

Two rules pulling against each other: decide which wins, and when.

> A Halden bid writer put "Use numbered paragraphs and British spelling" in her account-wide Instructions for Claude.
>
> Her bid drafts follow it; her colleagues' drafts in the same bid Project do not.

What is the best fix?

A. Ask every bid writer to copy the rule into their own Instructions for Claude

B. Move the rule into the bid Project's instructions, so it applies to everyone working there

C. Switch every writer to the Formal style

D. Ask writers to type the rule into each prompt

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

What is the best fix?

A Ask every bid writer to copy the rule into their own Instructions for Claude

Twelve copies to maintain, and they leak into every other chat.

B Move the rule into the bid Project's instructions, so it applies to everyone working there

A team rule in the team's layer.

C Switch every writer to the Formal style

A style sets tone, not numbering or house rules.

D Ask writers to type the rule into each prompt

Relies on memory, every prompt, every writer.

THE SIGNAL

A team rule in one person's account: move it to the Project.

In five lines

- **Purpose and boundaries first,** then role, standards, conditional rules, test.
- **Specific beats vague:** "formal, no contractions" beats "professional".
- **Explain why, say what to do,** and write exceptions as if-then-otherwise rules.
- **Contradictions:** decide which rule wins, and when. Never add a third rule.
- **Layers:** styles per chat, account instructions for you, Project instructions for the team.

COMING UP

Next: knowledge, connectors, Skills and maintenance.